

Debate #1: Should We Ban Octopus Farming?

The possibility, even likelihood, that many non-human creatures have conscious experience (that is, an experience of what it is like to be that creature) is drawing increased attention and informed discussion. One implication of this concerns ethical issues related to our food choices as humans, and how we choose to produce those foods demanded by human consumers. Much of the production of animals for food (and animal products, such as dairy and eggs) has evolved over the past several decades into various forms of “factory farms.” In the United States the vast majority of cows, pigs, chickens, and turkeys raised for food spend all or part of their lives in factory farms. The same is true for dairy cows and egg-laying chickens. In large part due to over-fishing of wild populations, fish farming accounts for an ever-larger portion of the supply for global demand of fish for consumption.

We will center the debate on the octopus, a very different kind of intelligent animal — distantly related to humans along a very different evolutionary trajectory, whose behavior has been a focus of study in recent years. Along with this growth of research interest, global demand for octopus as food is on the rise, incentivizing companies to develop farming and mass-production protocols.

The topic of the debate is whether there should be a ban on the farming of octopus. Assume that this would take the form of a legal mandate in the United States, together with signatories to an international treaty administered by the United Nations.

The PRO teams will argue in favor of implementing a ban on the farming of octopus.

The CON teams will argue against implementation of a ban on the farming of octopus.

To get you started thinking about this issue, everyone should read the following two sources:

1. “The Case Against Octopus Farming”
Link: <https://issues.org/the-case-against-octopus-farming/>
2. “Octopus Aquaculture: Unethical or the Next Big Thing?”
Link: <https://www.globalseafood.org/advocate/octopus-aquaculture-unethical-or-the-next-big-thing/>

Please carefully review the posted “Guidelines for Discussion Section Debates.”

As indicated in those “Guidelines,” written assignments are due from EVERYONE. These should be hand-written and a photo should be submitted via bCourses by 11:59pm on Sunday October 4th.